

Research Plan for Weeks 3–6

1. Purpose of This Document

This document explains how we plan to conduct research during **Weeks 3–6**.

It answers four main questions:

1. Who will we speak to?
2. How will we speak to them?
3. What do we want to learn from each group?
4. When will each round of research happen?

This plan builds on the **Stakeholder Map** prepared.

The discussion questions below are based on the open questions already listed in the project proposal (Sections 9.1–9.9) and the assumptions identified during Weeks 1–2.

2. Research Objectives for Weeks 3–6

Each week will focus on a different part of the current final-project process.

Together, these research activities should help us:

- update the Draft Current-State Process Map created during Weeks 1–2;
- understand how the process actually works;
- check the assumptions identified during Weeks 1–2;
- identify areas that are still unclear.

Week	Focus	Main Objective
3	Current Student Research	Understand how current students manage project work, meetings and documentation.
4	Previous Student Research	Understand the experience of students who have already completed their projects, including what worked, what was lost and what they wish had been available.
5	Mentor Research	Understand how mentors guide projects, review progress, give feedback and manage information across projects.
6	Programme Research + Existing Tools Review	Understand what information is needed at the programme level and complete the review of tools and documents currently being used.

3. Research Methods

We plan to use two methods during Weeks 3–6.

The method used with each group depends on the number of people involved and their availability.

3.1 One-on-One Interviews

We will conduct one-on-one interviews with all stakeholder groups.

We will use a prepared set of questions, but the order will remain flexible so that we can ask follow-up questions when participants mention something important.

For example, a participant may mention:

- a tool that was not previously known to us;
- an informal way of tracking work;
- a workaround used by students or mentors;
- a document or process that is not formally recorded.

Each stakeholder group has a separate discussion guide in Section 6.

3.2 Review of Existing Documents and Tools

This will happen alongside the interviews.

When participants mention a tool, tracker, template, document or other material, we will ask whether they can show us a representative or redacted example.

This will help us understand:

- what tools are actually being used;
- what information is stored in them;
- how different tools are used together;
- whether what participants describe matches what they actually use.

This information will be added to the **Existing Tools and Information** review.

3.3 Methods Not Being Used During Weeks 3–6

Surveys

We are not planning to use surveys during this round.

The PDM programme has a relatively small student population, with around **41 students in a batch**. Since the group is small, individual conversations can provide more detailed information than a survey.

Group Discussions

We are also not planning group discussions with students during this round.

Some experiences may be easier for students to discuss individually, especially topics such as:

- missed deadlines;
- difficulties with mentors;
- problems with project management;
- information that was lost or forgotten.

A short group discussion may be considered later if needed for checking findings.

4. Participant Groups

Participants are grouped based on how directly they are involved in the final-project process.

Within IIIT Hyderabad, PDM mentors may come from three centres:

- Software Engineering Research Centre (SERC)
- Cognitive Science Lab
- Centre for Innovation & Entrepreneurship (CIE)

We plan to speak to mentors from different centres because their mentoring and review processes may differ.

Group	Stakeholder Level	Target Sample	How We Will Select Participants
Current PDM Students (Sem 3–4, active final project)	Primary	6–8 students	Include a mix of individual and team projects. Where possible, include different types of projects, such as technical and research-focused projects.
Faculty Mentors	Primary	3–4 mentors	We already know
Previous PDM Students	Secondary	4–5 alumni	Include students from completed batches. Availability will be more important than how recently they graduated.
PDM Programme Coordinator	Secondary	1	Speak to the designated programme coordinator.

Reviewers, if different from mentors	Secondary	1–2, if applicable	First confirm with the Programme Coordinator whether reviewers are a separate stakeholder group. Interview them only if they have a separate role.
Future Batch Representatives	Tertiary	Deferred	Not planned for Weeks 3–6. The usefulness of past project information will first be explored through previous students and the Programme Coordinator.

Planned Number of Interviews

Approximately **16–22 interviews** are planned across Weeks 3–6.

These interviews will need to fit within the research time available for this phase.

5. Participant Recruitment

Current Students and Mentors

Current students and mentors will be approached directly.

Where needed, we may ask the Programme Coordinator for help so that we do not speak only to students working under the same mentor.

Previous Students

Previous students may be contacted through:

- available contact information from the existing PDM archive;
- faculty introductions;
- other available programme contacts.

At present, we do not have a direct communication channel with alumni.

Information Given to Participants

Before each interview, participants will be told that:

- this research is part of the PDM Final Project Lifecycle project;
- we are trying to understand the current process;
- their responses will be kept anonymous in shared findings unless they agree to be identified.

6. Timeline — Weeks 3–6

The research is planned across four weeks.

Each week will include:

- participant scheduling;
- interviews;
- note-taking;
- reviewing findings;
- preparation for the following week.

Week	Group(s)	Activities	Output
3	Current Students	Recruit and schedule 6–8 students. Conduct 30–40 minute interviews. Record notes on the same day.	Student interview notes and an initial understanding of the student-side project journey.
4	Previous Students	Recruit 4–5 previous students. Conduct approximately 30-minute interviews. Compare their responses with existing archive information where useful.	Previous-student findings and information about problems experienced during or after project completion.
5	Faculty Mentors	Recruit 4–6 mentors across SERC, Cognitive Science Lab and CIE. Conduct 40–45 minute interviews. Ask to see sample review materials where participants are comfortable sharing them.	Mentor interview findings and a clearer understanding of the review and feedback process.
6	Programme Coordinator + Existing Tools Review	Conduct a 45-minute Programme Coordinator interview. Confirm whether reviewers are a separate stakeholder group. Combine the tool and document information collected during previous weeks.	Programme-level process findings and completed list of existing tools and documents.

By the end of Week 6, the open questions identified during Weeks 1–2 should either:

- have an answer; or
- remain marked as open, with a clear reason.

The findings from Weeks 3–6 will then be used in **Weeks 7–8: Identify the Main Problems**.

7. Interview Discussion Guides

Each interview guide follows the same general structure:

1. Introduction

2. Warm-up
3. Main questions
4. Wrap-up

Using a similar structure will help us compare responses across participants while still allowing follow-up questions where needed.

7.1 Discussion Guide — Current Students

Participant Group	Current PDM student working individually or as part of a team on an active final project
Duration	30–40 minutes
Mode	In person or video call, one-on-one
Goal	Understand how students currently manage their final project, from mentor allocation through ongoing project work.

Introduction — Approximately 2 Minutes

1. Thank the participant for their time.
2. Explain that the purpose of the conversation is to understand how the current final-project process works.
3. Clarify that we are not evaluating the participant or their project.
4. Explain that no software solution has been decided.
5. Tell them that honest descriptions of what currently works and what does not work are useful.
6. Ask for permission to take notes and, if applicable, record the conversation.

Warm-up — Approximately 3 Minutes

1. Can you briefly describe your project?
2. Are you working individually or as part of a team?
3. Roughly what stage is your project currently at?

Mentor Allocation

1. Can you walk me through how you got your current mentor?
2. Did you rank mentor preferences?
3. How did you decide which mentors to choose?
4. Was the final mentor allocation what you expected?
5. Was anything about the allocation process unclear?

Project Direction and Proposal

1. After your mentor was assigned, how did you decide what project to work on?
2. Did you prepare a formal project proposal?
3. If yes, what format did you use?
4. How many project directions or ideas did you consider before selecting one?

Day-to-Day Project Management

1. Can you walk me through how you currently keep track of your project work?
2. How do you manage:
 - tasks;
 - deadlines;
 - decisions?
3. What tools or documents do you currently use?

Possible follow-up examples:

- notebook;
 - Google Drive;
 - Notion;
 - WhatsApp;
 - spreadsheet.
4. Is there anything you currently track that you wish was easier to manage?
 5. Is there anything you stopped tracking because it required too much effort?

Mentor Meetings and Feedback

1. How often do you meet your mentor?
2. How are those meetings scheduled?
3. Can you walk me through what happened in your most recent mentor meeting?
4. Are meeting notes or minutes recorded?
5. If yes, who records them?
6. Where are they stored?
7. How do you keep track of action items between one meeting and the next?
8. Has anything discussed in a meeting ever been forgotten or lost?
9. If yes, what happened?

Documents and Project Materials

1. What documents or files have you created so far for the project?
2. Where are they currently stored?
3. Are they all stored in one place?
4. If your teammate or mentor asked for a document from three weeks ago, how easily could you find it?

Wrap-up — Approximately 3 Minutes

1. If you could change one thing about the way final projects currently work, what would it be?
2. Is there anything important about the process that I did not ask about?
3. Thank the participant and explain what will happen with the research findings.

7.2 Discussion Guide — Previous Students

Participant Group	Previous PDM student who completed the full final-project process
Duration	Approximately 30 minutes
Mode	Video call, one-on-one
Goal	Understand their experience after completing the full process, including what worked, what was lost and what they feel could have helped.

Introduction — Approximately 2 Minutes

1. Thank the participant for taking the time to speak with us.
2. Explain that we want to understand the complete final-project experience from someone who has already been through it.
3. Explain that previous students may be able to tell us things that current students have not yet experienced.

Warm-up — Approximately 2 Minutes

1. Can you remind me of your project title?
2. Roughly when did you complete it?

Looking Back at the Process

1. Looking back, how would you describe your overall experience of managing the project?
2. What parts were smooth?
3. What parts were difficult?
4. Was any part of the process more difficult than you think it needed to be?
5. Was there ever a point when you felt behind or lost track of something important?
6. If yes, what happened?

Documentation and Information Loss

1. Do you still have access to your project's:
 - documents;
 - decisions;
 - meeting notes?
2. Is there anything from your project that you know still exists somewhere but would be difficult to find now?

For example:

- a decision;
- research;
- a design file;
- meeting notes.

3. If a future student wanted to learn from or continue your project, what information would they currently be able to access?

Completion and Archive

1. What did completing the project involve?
2. What did you submit?
3. Who did you submit it to?
4. Do you know what happened to the project information after you graduated?
5. Did anyone from a later batch ever contact you about your project?
6. Did you ever contact a later batch about your work?

Looking Back

1. If you could give one piece of advice about the project process to a student starting today, what would it be?
2. Did you create any tool, template or personal method during your project that you wish had been available from the beginning?

Wrap-up — Approximately 2 Minutes

1. Is there anything else about your project experience that seems important, even if I did not ask about it?
2. Thank the participant.

7.3 Discussion Guide — Faculty Mentors

Participant Group	Faculty mentor currently supervising one or more PDM final projects from SERC, Cognitive Science Lab or CIE
Duration	40–45 minutes
Mode	In person, one-on-one
Goal	Understand how mentors currently guide projects, monitor progress, review work, give feedback and manage information across projects.

Introduction — Approximately 2 Minutes

1. Thank the mentor for their time.
2. Explain that this is an early attempt to understand the current final-project process.
3. Clarify that we are not presenting or testing a particular software solution.
4. Explain that we are speaking with mentors from SERC, Cognitive Science Lab and CIE because the way projects are mentored may differ across centres.

Warm-up — Approximately 3 Minutes

1. Roughly how many final-project students or teams are you currently mentoring?
2. How long have you been mentoring PDM final projects?

Mentor Allocation

1. How do you currently decide which students or teams you will mentor?
2. What happens when several students select you as a mentor preference?
3. Is there anything about the current mentor-allocation process that you think could work differently?

Monitoring Project Progress

1. How do you currently keep track of the progress of each project you mentor?
2. What information do you usually need before a meeting or review?
3. Is there any information that you repeatedly have to ask students to provide?
4. How do you notice when a project may be falling behind?

Meetings, Feedback and Action Items

1. How are meetings with students usually scheduled?
2. How are the meetings usually conducted?
3. Do you keep a record of:
 - decisions;
 - feedback;
 - action items?
4. If yes, where and how do you record them?
5. How do you check whether students acted on feedback given during an earlier meeting?

Information About Other Projects

1. Do you currently have any information about projects being mentored by other faculty members?
2. Would having this information be useful to you?
3. Or is information about your own projects sufficient?
4. Is there any information about the projects you mentor that should not be visible to other mentors or programme staff?

Reviews and Completion

1. Are there formal project reviews in addition to your regular meetings with students?
2. Are there programme-level or panel reviews?
3. Who else is usually involved in these reviews?
4. In your view, what makes a project complete?

Wrap-up — Approximately 3 Minutes

1. If you could make one part of the mentoring process easier, what would it be?
2. Is there anything about the current process that you expected us to ask about but we did not?
3. Thank the mentor.

7.4 Discussion Guide — PDM Programme Coordinator

Participant Group	PDM Programme Coordinator
Duration	Approximately 45 minutes
Mode	In person, one-on-one
Goal	Understand how the programme tracks projects across the batch, how reviews work, what defines project completion and how completed projects are stored.

Introduction — Approximately 2 Minutes

1. Thank the coordinator for their time.
2. Explain that we are trying to understand the complete final-project process before suggesting any changes or solutions.

Programme-Level Project Information

1. Do you currently have information about all final projects across the batch, or only at certain points in the process?
2. How do you find out how a particular project or mentor-student pair is progressing?
3. Is there currently any batch-level report, spreadsheet or other method used to track projects?
4. How do you identify projects that may be delayed or facing problems?

Mentor Allocation

1. What is your role in the mentor-preference and allocation process?
2. What happens when mentor preferences cannot be matched easily?

For example:

- several students prefer the same mentor;
- none of the selected mentors can take a student or team.

Reviews and Reviewers

1. Are there people involved in project reviews who are different from the supervising mentor?
2. If yes, who are they?
3. At what stage do they become involved?
4. How are review decisions or results recorded?
5. How are those decisions communicated?

Completion and Archive

1. From the programme's side, what formally makes a project complete?
2. What happens to project materials after completion?
3. Who decides what information should be kept?

4. How is the existing PDM project archive, including projects from batches such as January 2022 and July 2022, currently maintained?
5. Do future students access this archive?
6. If yes, do you know how often they use it or what they use it for?

Tools Used at Programme Level

1. What tools or systems do you currently use to manage programme-level project information?
2. Where is information about:
 - mentors;
 - students;
 - projects
 currently stored?

Wrap-up — Approximately 3 Minutes

1. If there is one programme-level information gap you would like to address, what would it be?
2. Is there anyone else involved in the final-project process who you think we should speak to?
3. Thank the coordinator.

9. Connecting Research to Our Assumptions

Each assumption identified during Weeks 1–2 will be checked through the relevant interviews.

ID	Current Assumption	Main Research Source
A1	Students use multiple tools to manage projects.	Current Student interviews — Week 3
A2	Mentors may not have enough information about projects outside the ones they directly mentor.	Faculty Mentor interviews — Week 5
A3	Decisions and action items from meetings may not always be recorded clearly.	Current Student and Faculty Mentor interviews — Weeks 3 and 5
A4	Programme stakeholders may need information about project progress across the batch.	Programme Coordinator interview — Week 6
A5	Information from previous projects may be difficult for future students to find or reuse.	Previous Student interviews — Week 4 and Programme Coordinator interview — Week 6

A6	One common digital system may improve the process.	This will remain an open assumption. We will not ask participants directly whether they want one system. We will only consider it later if the need appears naturally across several interviews.
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10. Expected Output by the End of Week 6

By the end of Week 6, the research should produce:

- current student interview notes;
- findings from previous students;
- faculty mentor findings;
- programme-level process findings;
- a completed list of the tools and documents currently being used.

These findings will be used during **Weeks 7–8: Identify the Main Problems.**

During Weeks 7–8, we will:

- bring the research findings together;
- update the current project lifecycle based on what we learned;
- identify repeated problems;
- decide which problem is important and realistic enough to take forward.